Revision Notes for Class 9

Social Science - Civics (Democratic Politics)

Chapter - 1 What is Democracy? Why Democracy?

Definition of Democracy

- It is defined as a form of government where rulers are elected by the choice of the people.
- So, the difference between democratic and non-democratic governments is that the power to elect their representative is in the people's hands.

Examples of Non-Democratic Governments

- In Myanmar, the army controller becomes the ruler and the people over have no role to play in electing their representative.
- In Saudi Arabia, the representatives are from royal families, this is the base on which they qualify to become kings. Here also, people have no role to play in making decisions.

Features of Democracy

- **Free and Fair Elections:** In a democracy, elections are held regularly where citizens have the right to choose their leaders without coercion or manipulation.
- **Majority Rule:** Decisions in a democracy are made based on the opinion of the majority, while also protecting the rights of minorities.
- **Protection of Rights:** Democracies ensure the protection of individual rights and freedoms, such as freedom of speech, religion, and expression.
- **Accountability of Government:** Elected leaders are accountable to the people, and they must answer for their actions and decisions.

- **Rule of Law:** Everyone, including government officials, is subject to the law, and laws are applied equally to all citizens.
- **Citizen Participation:** Democracy encourages active participation from its citizens in political processes, through voting, protests, and discussions.

Major Decisions by the Elected Leaders

- Pakistani General Pervez Musharraf, in October 1999 led the military and overthrew a democratic government and declared himself the 'Chief Executive'.
- In the year 2002, he changed his designation to President and declared himself an additional 5 years.
- In the year August 2002, he passed the 'Legal Framework Order' which stated that the President could dismiss the national and provincial assemblies.
- After elections, elected candidates vested some powers, the final power rested with military officers and General Musharraf. It shows that it is not a democratic country.
- In the USSR in communist Poland and the US in contemporary Iraq, power lay with external instead of elected locals. Whereas in democracy, the final power lies with those who are elected by the people.

Free and Fair Electoral Competition

- In China, to elect members for the country's parliament which is called Quanguo Renmin Daibiao Dahui (National People's Congress), elections are held every 5 years.
- Candidate needs to be a member of the Chinese Communist Party or 8 of its allies to contest elections in 2002-03.
- The communist party used to form the government.
- Since its independence, in 1930, Mexico's presidential elections have been held every 6 years. Until 2000 every election was won by the PRI (Institutional Revolutionary Party).
- A fair and free electoral competition where the existing ruling party has a fair chance to lose is an aspect of democracy.
- Examples of Democracy are – India and the United States etc.

One Person, One Vote, One Value

- Political equality is the basis of democracy.
- A few instances where equal rights are denied have been observed.
- Women had no right to vote until 2015, in Saudi Arabia.
- In Estonia, citizen rules made it very difficult for people from Russian minorities to gain the right to vote.
- Fiji's electoral system gave more value to indigenous Fiji than Indian-Fijian.
- These are some examples which contradict the basis of democracy where an adult citizen must have one vote with equal value.

Rule of Law and Respect for Rights

- In the year 1980, Zimbabwe gained independence. The leader Robert Mugabe of the ZANU-PF party, which led the freedom struggle ruled the country.
- President Mugabe used malpractices in elections so that ZANU-PF always won.
- Only the verdicts of the ruling party were presented by the television and radio since a law existed that restricted the right to criticize the President.
- Harassment was done to the independent journalist who talked against the government.
- Hence, in a democratic government:
- Major decisions were taken by the rulers elected by the people.
- Fair choice of people in changing rulers.
- Equal opportunity to all the citizens in choosing their representative.
- The government's power is limited by the basic rules of the constitution.

Arguments Against Democracy

- Arguments of instability may arise because the government is changed frequently:
- Political competition and power play can take dominance over morality.
- Delay in decision-making because of multiple consultations.
- A lack of knowledge in the public interest can result in wrong decision-making.
- Democracy is based on electoral competition, it brings corruption.
- People electing their representatives may be unaware of their well-being.

Arguments in Favour of Democracy

- A democratic government is always a better government since it is an accountable form of government.
- Democracy improves decision-making quality.
- Democracy gives a method to deal with differences and conflicts.
- Democracy enhances citizens' dignity.
- Democracy is better compared to other forms of government since it allows us to correct our mistakes.

Broader Meaning of Democracy

- Under representative democracy, everyone does not rule. The elected representative decides on behalf of their people:
- Modern democracies are characterized by huge populations; which makes it impossible for them to make the right decision.
- If they could make the right decision, citizens would not have a greater amount of time, and the skill to play a role in all the decisions.
- Understanding democracy can help people identify the weaknesses of existing democracy and can differentiate between minimal and good democracy.

Democracy in India

- India is seen as the largest democracy in the world.
- Since independence, citizens have been given the right to vote and have equal rights in voting without considering their caste, religion, gender or colour.
- Democratic principles by which the Indian government functions are: sovereign, socialist, secular, democratic and republic.
- Elections are held after every 5 years.
- Government officials work under the Election Commission during election days.

What are the Merits of Democracy?

- In a democracy, the dignity of citizens is maintained.
- It improves the quality of decision-making.
- Provides a path for resolving conflicts.
- The form of government is more accountable.
- The government abides by the Constitution as it is answerable to the citizens.

Some Important Definitions and Questions from the Chapter

Define Democracy

Democracy is a form of governance in which the people directly or indirectly decide on laws, policies, leadership, and key initiatives for a state or other polity.

Define Representative Democracy

In a representative democracy, a majority of elected representatives have the authority to make choices on behalf of all the people, rather than all the people ruling or making decisions.

Which kind of Democracy is More Prevalent in the Modern World?

The most prevalent type of democracy in today's world is a representative democracy.

When can we declare elections to be fair?

To be deemed fair, elections must provide voters with a genuine selection of political options.

Define referendum

A referendum is a general vote in which all voters are asked to accept or reject a proposition.

1. Why is a democratic form of government most popular?

Ans: Some features of democracy make it the most popular form of government:

- In a democracy, the government is accountable for the public interests. Decision-making is not completely dependent on the ruler.
- This form of government makes all decisions about the best of their people.
- A passive resolution to every predicament is provided in democracy.
- Democracy is the best method for dealing with conflicts in ideology.
- Countries like India have a vast diversity of religions, languages, castes and creeds, one solution leads to unity.
- Political equality is maintained in democracy by giving equal priority to the poor, educated and uneducated.

2. What is direct democracy and why can it not be implemented in modern times?

Ans: Direct democracy is a form of democracy where citizens share an equal role in the decision-making process.

- Modern democracies consist of a large amount of people, and it is not physically possible for them to sit together and make a decision.
- All citizens do not have the time or skill to take part in the entire decision-making.

3. Why is the most common form of democratic government representative democracy?

Ans: Representative democracy is a form of democracy in which the majority of people rule through their elected representatives.

- This kind of democracy is realistic and huge democracies as all people do not have desired qualifications to rule.
- So, direct rule is not possible.
- Hence, the majority through their elected representative is allowed to make decisions on behalf of all the people.
- So, representative democracy is required where elected people can make collective decisions.

4. What are the basic differences between good and minimal democracy?

Ans: The differences between good and minimal democracy are:

S.No.	**Minimal democracy**	**Good democracy**
	The rulers are elected by the people.	People elect their rulers and also take part in all the decisions.

	Regular elections are held in a minimal democracy.	Regular free and fair elections are held in good democracy.
	Political equality is there in minimal democracy.	Political but also socio-economical unity is also an aspect of a good democracy.

5. What are the common features of a non-democratic government?

Ans: Ideologies of a non-democratic government are:

- In non-democratic countries, criticizing the government may lead to oppressive actions such as harassment, imprisonment etc.
- No elections are held as it is ruled by the king or military.
- There is no place for the opposition party.
- Unions which abide by the government policies are welcome.
- The final words of the dictator or the military rulers are taken into consideration.
- Common people cannot think of high positions in government.

6. Give a classic example of a better response of a democratic government over a non-democratic one.

Ans: In China 1958-1961, the word recorded famine. The casualties were around three crores of China's population.

- India was economically weaker compared to China, but it was not hit by famine as China.
- It was believed it was the government policies of the country that created such a scenario.
- Indian democratic responded well to food scarcity.
- The existence of multi-party elections, an opposition party and a press free to criticize the government might have saved China from huge famine casualties.